The Party's Over: How the Bitcoin ETF Killed Crypto's Cool Factor

David Krause, Emeritus Associate Professor of Finance, Marquette University

Abstract

This paper documents a structural break in the risk return characteristics and cultural relevance of cryptocurrencies following the approval of the first spot Bitcoin ETF on January 10, 2024. Using daily price data from January 2021 to June 2026, we compare pre ETF and post ETF performance metrics, betas, and event study cumulative abnormal returns for Bitcoin, Dogecoin, and Ethereum relative to the S&P 500 and gold. We then introduce two independent measures of public interest, Google Trends and Wikipedia page views, to test the hypothesis that Bitcoin lost its cultural "coolness" after institutionalization. The findings are striking. Dogecoin, the quintessential speculative asset, saw its Sharpe ratio collapse from 0.30 pre ETF to 0.01 post ETF, while its annualized return fell from 63.17% to 2.82%. Google search interest for Dogecoin declined 63.1% and its Wikipedia page views collapsed 75.9%. Searches for "how to buy Bitcoin," a proxy for new retail entrants, declined 22.7%. In contrast, general "cryptocurrency" interest fell 47.5%, while Bitcoin maintained a stable Sharpe ratio and saw its beta relative to the S&P 500 decline from 1.33 to 1.11. An event study reveals that the Trump 2024 election produced a +47.37% cumulative abnormal return for Dogecoin, but this proved temporary. The MSTR sale in May 2026, Michael Saylor's first Bitcoin sale since 2022, generated a -6.56% abnormal return for Bitcoin. These results support the thesis that ETF approval marked a cultural as well as financial regime shift, as retail speculative energy exited the crypto market and Bitcoin moved toward more of a diversifier role.

Keywords: Bitcoin, cryptocurrency, ETF, event study, institutionalization, speculative assets, Dogecoin, Google Trends, Wikipedia

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1. Introduction

The approval of the first spot Bitcoin exchange traded fund (ETF) by the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) on January 10, 2024 was widely seen as a turning point for cryptocurrency markets. Supporters argued that ETF approval would bring institutional capital, reduce volatility, and legitimize Bitcoin as an asset class. Two and a half years later, Bitcoin's price has stagnated relative to traditional assets, retail enthusiasm has waned, and prominent crypto advocates have begun selling portions of their holdings.

This paper asks a different question. Has Bitcoin's social meaning changed? Is it no longer the cool investment to own? We argue that ETF approval marked a structural break not just in price dynamics but in the cultural and risk return characteristics of crypto assets. Prior to the ETF, Bitcoin and its peers were dominated by a "you only live once" (YOLO) speculative mentality, retail investors seeking asymmetric upside, often influenced by anti-establishment podcasters and social media influencers. Post ETF, Bitcoin began to behave more like a traditional diversifier, with lower beta, modest Sharpe ratios, and reduced drawdown severity. Meanwhile, the speculative crypto energy migrated to Dogecoin and other memecoins, where it produced extreme returns during the period surrounding the Trump election but subsequently faded, leaving Dogecoin with a near zero Sharpe ratio by mid-2026.

To test this thesis, we conduct three empirical exercises. First, we compare pre ETF and post ETF performance metrics including annualized returns, volatility, Sharpe ratios, maximum drawdowns, and betas for Bitcoin, Ethereum, and Dogecoin relative to the S&P 500 and gold. Second, we perform an event study around five key dates: the ETF approval itself, the Trump election, the November 2025 tariff crash, the February 2026 Iran war onset, and the May 2026 Strategy (MSTR) sale. Third, we introduce two independent measures of public interest, Google Trends and Wikipedia page views, to directly measure the cultural "coolness" of these assets over time.

Our results strongly support the institutionalization thesis. Dogecoin's Sharpe ratio collapsed from 0.30 pre ETF to 0.01 post ETF, while its annualized return dropped from 63.17% to 2.82%. Bitcoin's Sharpe ratio remained stable, moving from 0.13 to 0.19, and its beta relative to the S&P 500 declined from 1.33 to 1.11. The event study reveals that the Trump election produced a staggering +47.37% five day cumulative abnormal return for Dogecoin, but this proved temporary. By the MSTR sale eighteen months later, all three crypto assets experienced negative abnormal returns, with Bitcoin falling -6.56%. Google search interest for Dogecoin declined 63.1% and its Wikipedia page views collapsed 75.9%. Searches for "how to buy Bitcoin" declined 22.7%, indicating fewer new retail entrants. In contrast, general "cryptocurrency" interest fell 47.5%. Contemporary market commentary, including statements from Strategy

chairman Michael Saylor, explicitly confirmed the capital rotation into artificial intelligence as a driver of Bitcoin's decline (Hitchcock, 2026).

The remainder of this paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 describes our data and methodology. Section 3 presents the empirical results. Section 4 discusses the implications for understanding speculative asset dynamics. Section 5 concludes and outlines directions for future research.

2. Data and Methodology

2.1 Data Sources

We obtain daily closing prices from Yahoo Finance for five assets over the period January 1, 2021 to June 4, 2026. The assets and their tickers are Bitcoin (BTC USD), Dogecoin (DOGE USD), Ethereum (ETH USD), the S&P 500 (GSPC), and gold represented by the GLD ETF. We include Ethereum in the analysis as an intermediate case, positioned between Bitcoin's institutional trajectory and Dogecoin's pure speculative status, to test whether the cultural cooling extended to a more established but still non-Bitcoin cryptocurrency.

We define the pre ETF period as January 1, 2021 to January 10, 2024, and the post ETF period as January 10, 2024 to June 4, 2026. All returns are calculated as daily percentage changes. The risk free rate is assumed to be 2% annually for Sharpe ratio calculations.

For our coolness metrics, we manually download Google Trends data for four search terms: Bitcoin, Ethereum, Dogecoin, and cryptocurrency. We also download data for "how to buy Bitcoin" as a proxy for new retail entrants. The time range is set to January 1, 2021 to June 4, 2026, with worldwide region selected. We also download Wikipedia page view data for the same topics from the Wikimedia pageview API via the manual download tool at pageviews.wmcloud.org.

Google Trends and Wikipedia page views were selected as our primary coolness metrics because they provide direct, quantifiable measures of public attention that are independent of price movements. Unlike social media sentiment, which can be driven by automated accounts or coordinated campaigns, search behavior and information seeking reflect genuine voluntary interest from real users.

2.2 Performance Metrics

For each asset and time period, we compute total return as the percentage change from start to end price. Annualized return is calculated as one plus total return raised to the power of 252 divided by the number of trading days, minus one. Annualized volatility is daily standard deviation multiplied by the square root of 252. The Sharpe ratio is annualized return minus the average risk free rate of 2% divided by annualized volatility. Maximum drawdown is the minimum of price minus running maximum divided by running maximum over the period. Beta relative to the S&P 500 is calculated as the covariance of asset returns with market returns divided by the variance of market returns.

2.3 Event Study Methodology

For each of five events, we calculate cumulative abnormal returns over two windows: a three day window of plus and minus one day and an eleven day window of plus and minus five days. Expected returns are estimated using the market model, where expected return equals beta multiplied by the market return. Beta is estimated from a 60 day pre event window. The abnormal return on a given day is the actual return minus the expected return. The cumulative abnormal return is the sum of abnormal returns over the event window. The S&P 500 serves as the market proxy.

The five events analyzed are the ETF approval on January 10, 2024, the Trump election on November 5, 2024, the tariff crash on November 21, 2025, the Iran war onset on February 28, 2026, and the MSTR sale on May 26, 2026. These events were selected because they represent distinct categories of potential market shocks: a regulatory milestone (ETF approval), a political event (Trump election), a macroeconomic policy shock (tariff crash), a geopolitical crisis (Iran war), and a firm specific credibility event (MSTR sale).

2.4 Coolness Metrics

Google Trends data provides a weekly search interest score from 0 to 100, where 100 represents peak popularity for that search term over the selected time period. For each search term, we calculate the average search interest in the pre ETF period and the post ETF period, then compute the percentage change.

Wikipedia page view data provides daily view counts. We calculate the average daily views in the pre ETF and post ETF periods, then compute the percentage change. For visualization, we apply a 90 day rolling average to both Google Trends and Wikipedia data to smooth weekly and daily fluctuations and reveal long term trends.

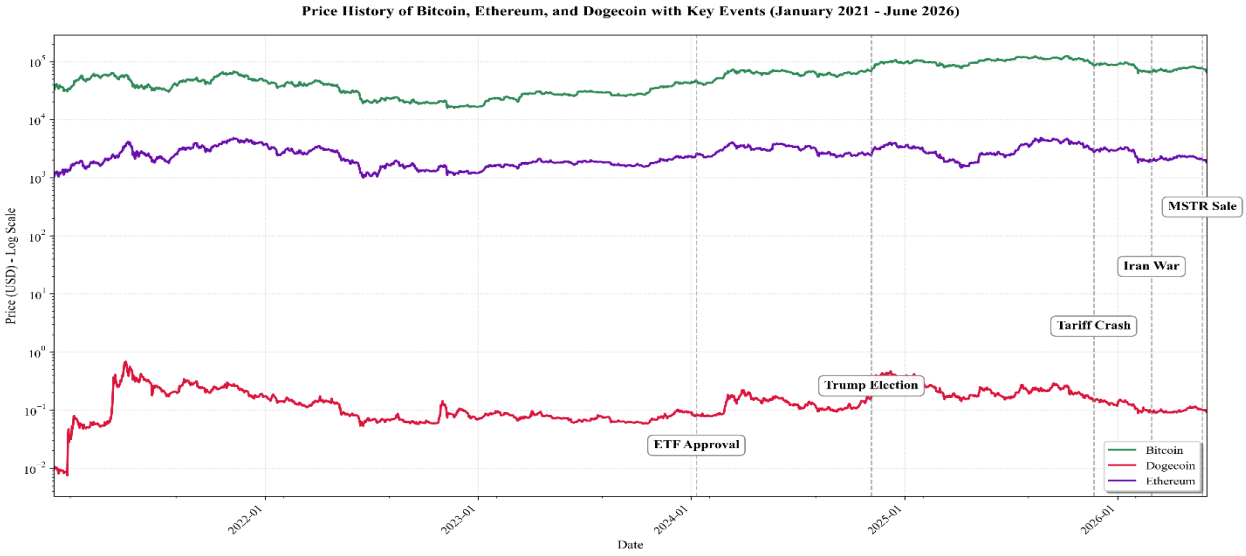
3. Results

3.1 Pre ETF and Post ETF Performance

Figure 1 reveals three distinct patterns. First, Dogecoin experienced an extraordinary price spike in 2021, reaching over $0.70, followed by a prolonged collapse. By mid-2026, Dogecoin traded below $0.10, representing a decline of more than 85% from its peak. Because the chart uses a logarithmic scale, the vertical distance between price levels represents percentage changes rather than absolute dollar changes. This allows meaningful visual comparison across assets with vastly different price levels, such as Bitcoin trading near $70,000 and Dogecoin trading near $0.10. The pattern shown in Figure 1 is consistent with a speculative mania driven by retail investors who subsequently exited the market. Second, Bitcoin shows a more moderate trajectory, with its post-ETF price range between $60,000 and $120,000, suggesting a slightly greater degree of price stabilization following institutionalization. Third, the five event markers show that the Trump

election occurred near a local peak for all three assets, while the MSTR sale coincided with a broad decline across the crypto market.

Figure 1. Price History of Bitcoin, Ethereum, and Dogecoin with Key Events (January 2021 - June 2026)



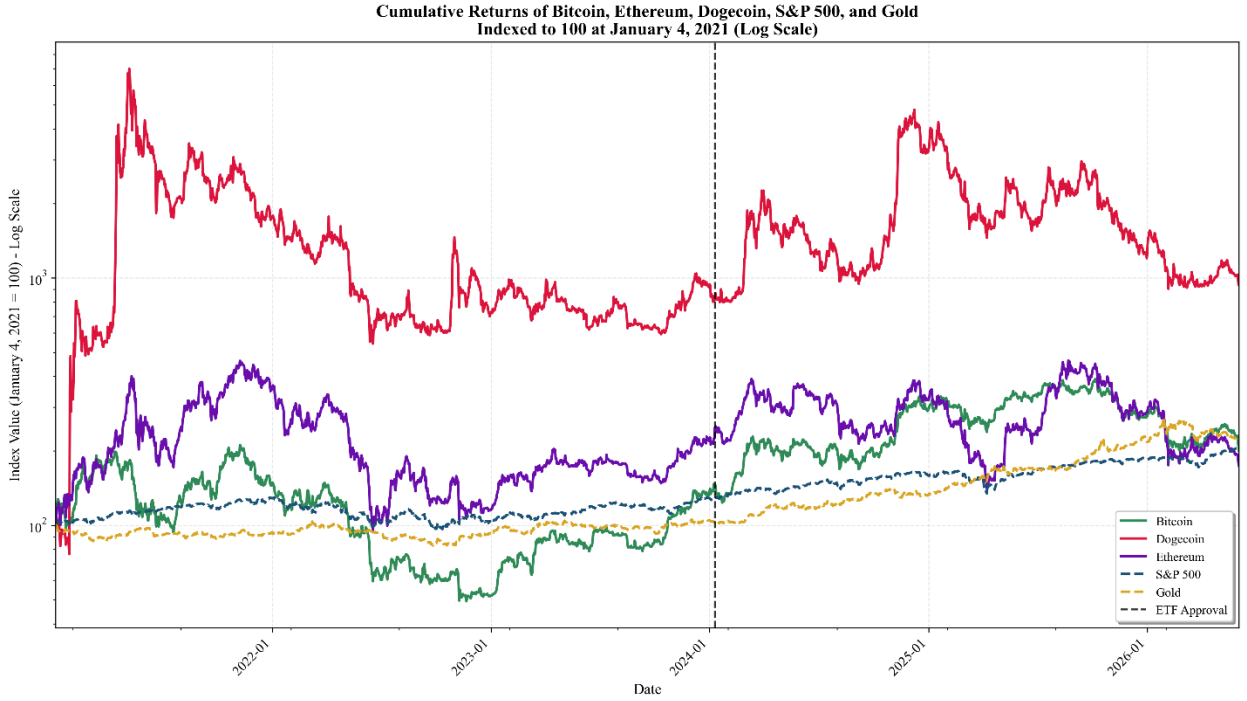
Notes: The chart shows daily closing prices on a logarithmic scale. Vertical dashed lines mark five key events: the spot Bitcoin ETF approval (January 10, 2024), the Trump election (November 5, 2024), the tariff-induced crash (November 21, 2025), the onset of the Iran War (February 28, 2026), and the MSTR sale (May 26, 2026).

Figure 2 presents cumulative returns indexed to 100 on a logarithmic scale. The log scale is essential because it allows comparison of Dogecoin's early massive gain with the S&P 500's modest gain without flattening the latter at the bottom of the chart.

Four patterns emerge. First, within the first few months Dogecoin reached over 7,000% return by May 2021, reflecting the memecoin frenzy driven by social media and retail speculation. After a sharp decline, a January 2021 investor still would have gained 835% by June 2026, but a peak buyer would have lost over 95% in investment value. Second, Ethereum peaked above 460% in August 2025 and ended at 175% overall return, showing less severe volatility. Third, Bitcoin peaked at 390% advance in October 2025 but ended at 200% return, with post-ETF stability suggesting partial institutionalization. Fourth, the S&P 500 and gold grew steadily by 204% and 224% respectively, with lower volatility than any crypto asset.

Figure 2 confirms the paper's central thesis. The speculative energy that drove crypto prices in early 2021 largely dissipated after the ETF approval. Bitcoin and Ethereum maintained positive but moderated growth, suggesting a partial transition toward traditional investment characteristics. Dogecoin, the purest speculative asset, experienced a dramatic and nearly complete collapse since May 2021.

Figure 2: Cumulative Returns of Bitcoin, Ethereum, Dogecoin, S&P 500, and Gold Indexed to 100 at Start (January 2021 - June 2026)



Notes: The chart shows cumulative returns on a logarithmic scale. All assets are indexed to 100 at the start date of January 1, 2021. A vertical dashed line marks the ETF approval date of January 10, 2024. The log scale allows comparison of percentage growth rates across assets with vastly different absolute returns.

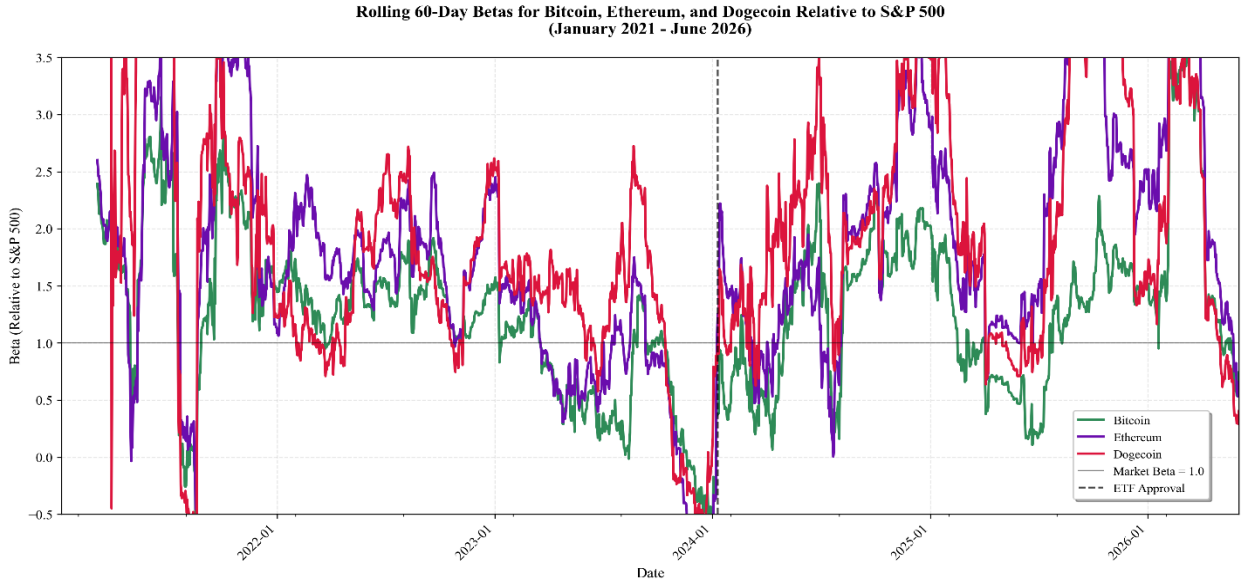
Table 1 reports annualized returns, volatility, Sharpe ratios, maximum drawdowns, and betas for the pre ETF period (January 1, 2021 to January 10, 2024) and the post ETF period (January 10, 2024 to June 4, 2026). Several findings stand out.

Table 1: Performance Metrics, Pre ETF vs Post ETF

Asset	Period	Ann. Return	Ann. Vol.	Sharpe Ratio	Max Drawdown	Beta
Bitcoin	Pre ETF	9.02%	53.40%	0.13	-76.63%	1.33
	Post ETF	9.56%	40.31%	0.19	-49.74%	1.11
Ethereum	Pre ETF	23.13%	68.68%	0.31	-79.35%	1.66
	Post ETF	-9.70%	57.72%	-0.20	-63.79%	1.76
Dogecoin	Pre ETF	63.17%	206.28%	0.30	-92.26%	2.07
	Post ETF	2.82%	78.30%	0.01	-81.11%	1.71
S&P 500	Pre ETF	6.05%	14.57%	0.28	-25.43%	1.00
	Post ETF	14.06%	12.92%	0.93	-18.90%	1.00
Gold	Pre ETF	0.64%	11.65%	-0.12	-21.03%	—
	Post ETF	25.09%	17.87%	1.29	-19.21%	—

The table reveals a clear hierarchy. Dogecoin, the purest speculative asset, saw its risk adjusted returns collapse to near zero. Bitcoin transitioned toward a diversifier role with lower volatility, lower beta, and improved drawdowns. Ethereum fell into negative risk adjusted performance, becoming more correlated with equities. Traditional assets delivered strong positive returns with low volatility. This pattern is consistent with the thesis that ETF approval marked a structural break in which institutional capital entered the crypto market, retail speculative energy exited, and Bitcoin began to mature as an asset class. Figure 3 provides a dynamic view of one key dimension of this transition: the evolution of betas over time.

Figure 3: Rolling 60-Day Betas for Bitcoin, Ethereum, and Dogecoin Relative to S&P 500 (January 2021 - June 2026)



Notes: The chart shows rolling 60-day betas calculated using daily returns. The horizontal line at 1.0 represents market beta. A vertical dashed line marks the ETF approval date of January 10, 2024.

Figure 3 shows three patterns. First, all three assets exhibited betas substantially above 1.0 prior to the ETF approval, indicating that crypto assets were significantly more volatile than the broader equity market. Dogecoin consistently showed the highest beta, often exceeding 2.5, consistent with its role as the most speculative asset. Second, following the ETF approval, both Bitcoin and Dogecoin show a clear downward trend in their betas. Bitcoin's beta declined from 1.33 to 1.11, while Dogecoin's beta fell from approximately 2.07 to 1.71. This suggests that institutionalization reduced the sensitivity of these assets to equity market movements. Third, unlike Bitcoin and Dogecoin, Ethereum's beta did not change much after the ETF approval, potentially due to its dual role as both a speculative asset and a platform for decentralized finance applications. The downward trend in Bitcoin and Dogecoin betas supports the thesis that ETF approval marked a transition toward lower correlation with equity markets, consistent with a diversifier role.

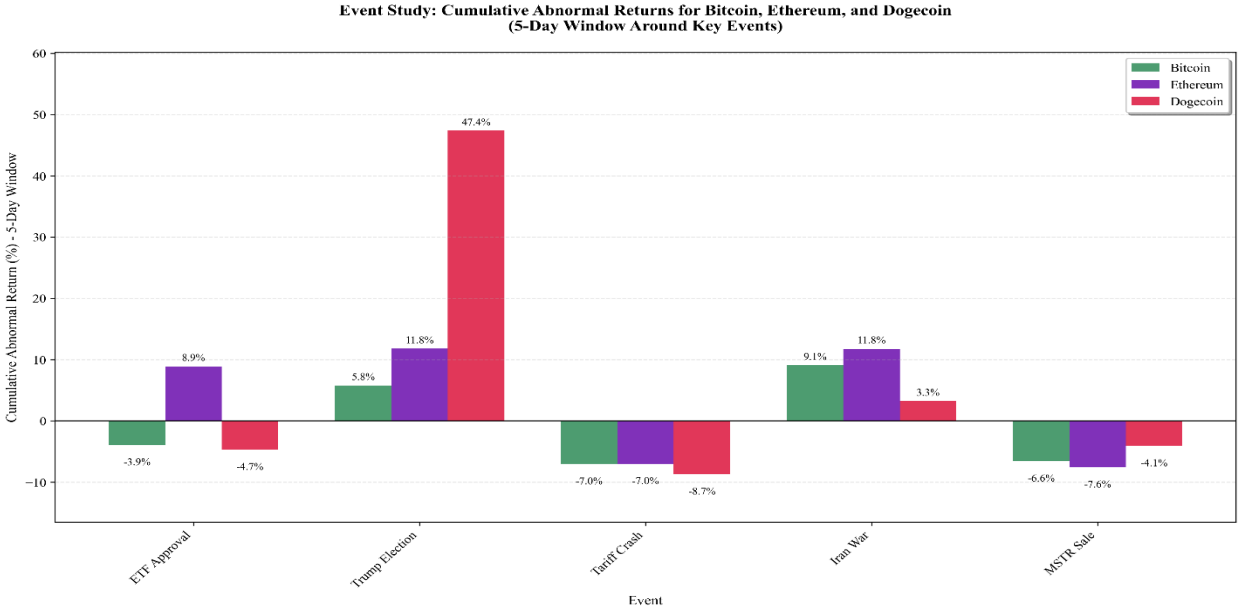
3.2 Event Study Results

Figure 4 presents cumulative abnormal returns for five key events. Three findings stand out. First, the Trump 2024 election produced an extraordinary +47.37% CAR for Dogecoin, compared to just +5.80% for Bitcoin and +11.80% for Ethereum. This divergence demonstrates Dogecoin's unique role as a speculation vehicle, highly sensitive to political narratives and anti-establishment sentiment. The Trump election appears to have been a temporary catalyst for the most speculative crypto asset, generating returns that far exceeded any fundamental justification.

Second, the MSTR sale on May 26, 2026, when Michael Saylor sold Bitcoin for the first time since 2022, generated negative CARs across all three assets. Bitcoin fell -6.56%, Ethereum fell -7.57%, and Dogecoin fell -4.11%. Notably, Dogecoin fell the least, consistent with the view that speculative investors had already exited the market by May 2026 and were therefore less sensitive to Saylor's credibility shock. For Bitcoin, the negative CAR suggests that evangelical credibility still matters for crypto prices, and Saylor's sale was interpreted as a negative signal.

Third, the Iran War onset on February 28, 2026 produced a positive CAR for Bitcoin (+9.10%) and Ethereum (+11.77%), but only a modest +3.26% for Dogecoin. This suggests that Bitcoin and Ethereum were treated as safe havens or geopolitical hedges during the conflict. The ETF approval event itself produced mixed results, with Bitcoin (-3.91%) and Dogecoin (-4.70%) experiencing negative CARs, while Ethereum (+8.92%) saw a positive reaction.

Figure 4: Event Study Cumulative Abnormal Returns for Bitcoin, Ethereum, and Dogecoin (5-Day Window Around Key Events)



Notes: The chart shows cumulative abnormal returns (CARs) over an 11-day window from 5 days before to 5 days after each event. Expected returns are estimated using the market model with the S&P 500 as the reference. A positive CAR indicates that the asset outperformed expectations; a negative CAR indicates underperformance.

Table 3 reports the cumulative abnormal returns for all three assets over a 3-day window that captures immediate market reactions. The Trump election still shows a strong Dogecoin spike (+18.02%), though less extreme than the 5-day window. The Iran war shows negative immediate reactions for all three assets (Bitcoin -1.04%, Dogecoin -3.80%, Ethereum -2.41%), suggesting the initial response was negative before prices recovered over the following week. This contrast between the 3-day and 5-day windows for the Iran war reveals that investors initially sold off, then bought back in as the geopolitical situation developed.

Table 3: Event Study Cumulative Abnormal Returns, 3-Day Window

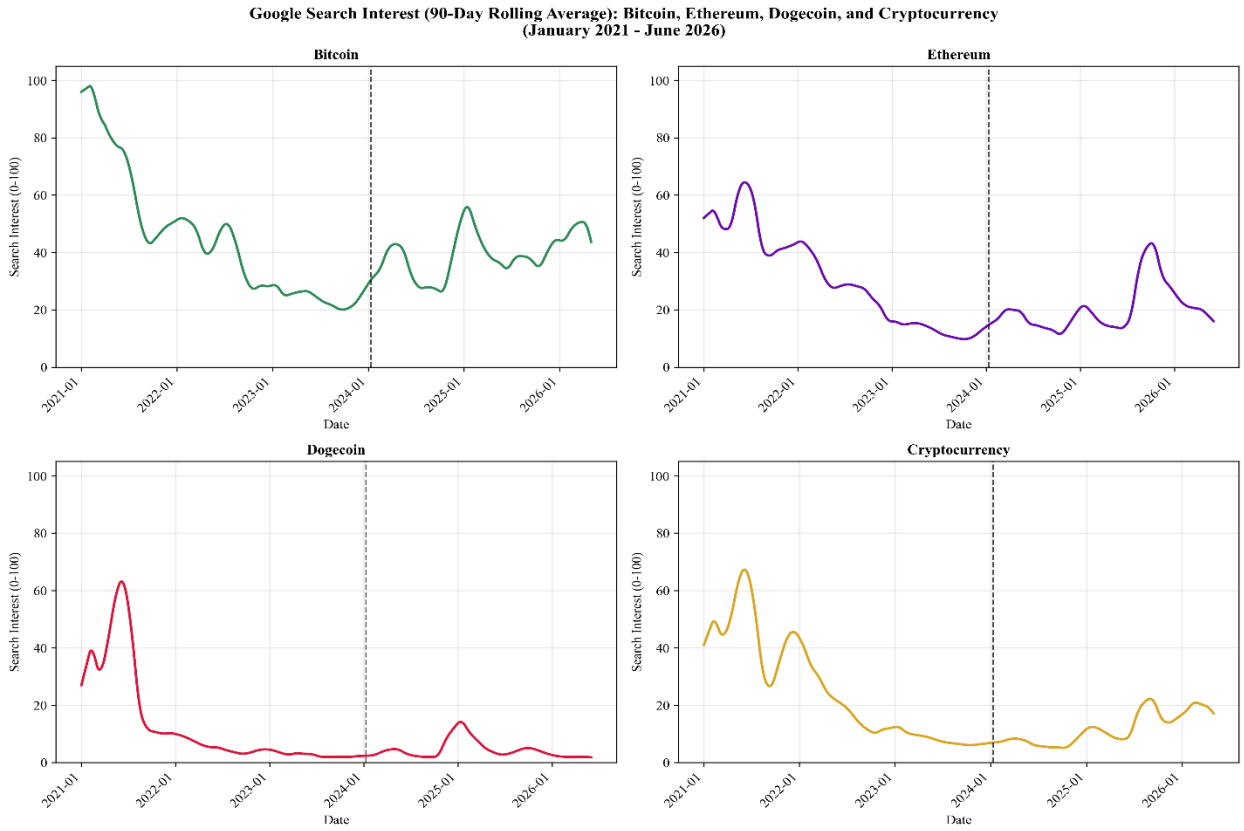
Event	Date	Bitcoin	Dogecoin	Ethereum
ETF Approval	10-Jan-24	-1.38%	3.81%	11.72%
Trump Election	5-Nov-24	3.96%	18.02%	2.46%
Tariff Crash	21-Nov-25	-6.65%	-7.23%	-7.12%
Iran War	28-Feb-26	-1.04%	-3.80%	-2.41%
MSTR Sale	26-May-26	-3.93%	-2.05%	-4.20%

Notes: Cumulative abnormal returns (CARs) are calculated over a 3-day window from 1 day before to 1 day after each event using the market model with the S&P 500 as reference.

3.3 Coolness Metrics: Google Trends

Figure 5 presents Google Trends search interest for four terms using a 90-day rolling average to reveal long term trends. Each panel shows a distinct pattern. Dogecoin exhibits the most dramatic decline, falling from peaks above 80 in 2021 to near zero by 2026. Ethereum shows a substantial decline from approximately 29 to 20, though less severe than Dogecoin. Cryptocurrency, the general term for the asset class, declines from approximately 30 to 12. Bitcoin, the most established asset, shows the smallest decline, falling from approximately 45 to 40. A vertical dashed line in each panel marks the ETF approval date of January 10, 2024. No sustained recovery occurs after this date for any of the four terms.

Figure 5: Google Search Interest (90-Day Rolling Average) - Bitcoin, Ethereum, Dogecoin, and Cryptocurrency (January 2021 - June 2026)



Notes: Each panel shows a 90-day rolling average of weekly search interest scores. Scores range from 0 to 100, where 100 represents peak popularity for each term. A vertical dashed line marks the ETF approval date of January 10, 2024.

Table 4 reports the average search interest scores for the pre ETF and post ETF periods for all five terms collected, including "How to Buy Bitcoin" as a proxy for new retail entrants. Dogecoin shows the largest decline at -63.1%, followed by Cryptocurrency at -47.5%, Ethereum at -30.6%, and Bitcoin at -6.6%. "How to Buy Bitcoin" declined 22.7%.

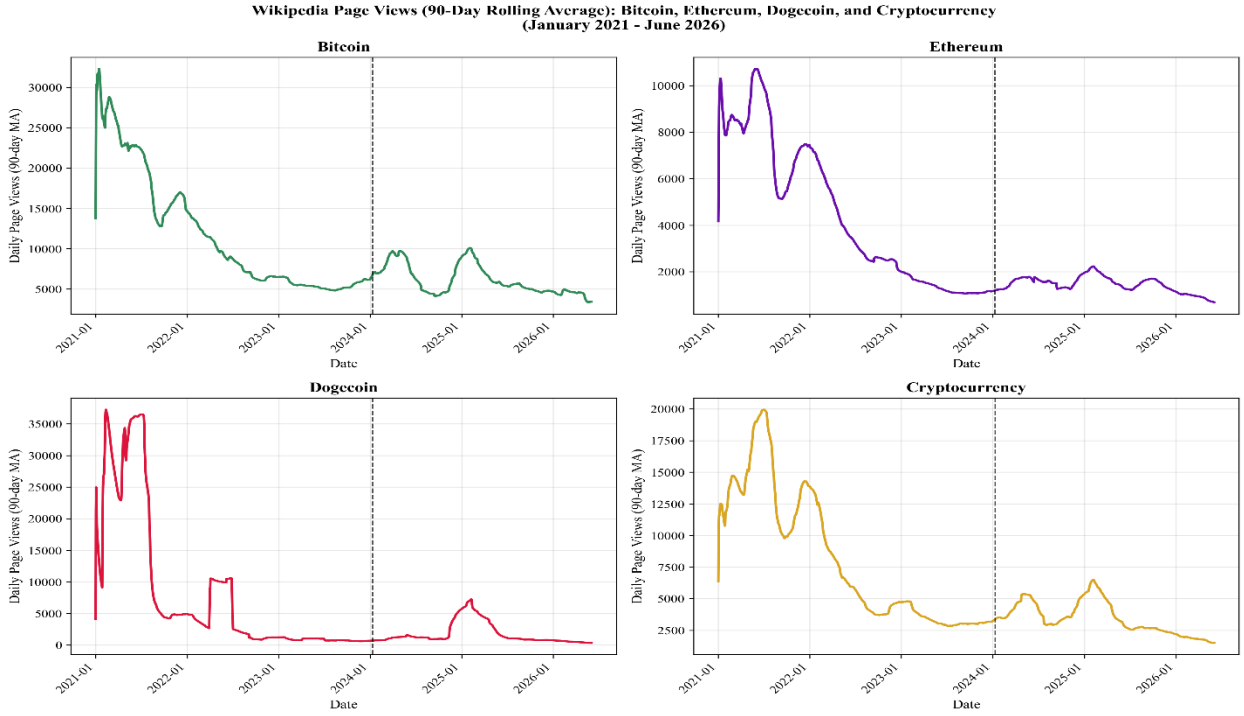
Table 4: Google Search Interest, Pre ETF vs Post ETF

Search Term	Pre ETF Average	Post ETF Average	Change
Bitcoin	42.3	39.5	-6.60%
Ethereum	29.2	20.3	-30.60%
Dogecoin	11.9	4.4	-63.10%
How to Buy Bitcoin	33.7	26.1	-22.70%
Cryptocurrency	23.4	12.3	-47.50%

3.4 Coolness Metrics: Wikipedia Page Views

Figure 6 presents Wikipedia page views for the same four topics using a 90-day rolling average. The patterns broadly confirm the Google Trends findings but with steeper declines. Dogecoin views collapse from peaks above 100,000 daily views in 2021 to under 2,000 by 2026, a decline of 75.9%. Ethereum views declined from approximately 4,000 to 1,400, a decrease of 65.0%. The Cryptocurrency page declines from approximately 7,700 to 3,400, a decline of 56.3%. Bitcoin views declined from 11,000 to 6,000, the smallest decline among the four at 45.3%. As in Figure 5, a vertical dashed line marks the ETF approval date, and no sustained recovery occurs afterward.

Figure 6: Wikipedia Page Views (90-Day Rolling Average) - Bitcoin, Ethereum, Dogecoin, and Cryptocurrency (January 2021 - June 2026)



Notes: Each panel shows a 90-day rolling average of daily page views to smooth daily fluctuations. A vertical dashed line marks the ETF approval date of January 10, 2024.

Table 5 reports the average daily page views for the pre ETF and post ETF periods. The hierarchy of declines matches Google Trends: Dogecoin falls the most (-75.9%), followed by Ethereum (-65.0%), Cryptocurrency (-56.3%), and Bitcoin (-45.3%). The convergence of these two independent data sources strengthens the conclusion that cultural relevance declined across all crypto topics following ETF approval, with the most speculative assets experiencing the steepest drops.

Table 5: Wikipedia Page Views, Pre ETF vs Post ETF

Page	Pre ETF Average	Post ETF Average	Change
Bitcoin	10,903	5,964	-45.3%
Ethereum	4,082	1,430	-65.0%
Dogecoin	7,237	1,746	-75.9%
Cryptocurrency	7,665	3,350	-56.3%

4. Discussion

Our results provide empirical support for the view that the January 2024 Bitcoin ETF approval represented a cultural as well as financial regime shift. The collapse of Dogecoin's Sharpe ratio from 0.30 to 0.01 is particularly striking. Dogecoin, which has no fundamental value proposition beyond its meme status and community enthusiasm, served as the canary in the coal mine for speculative crypto energy. When institutional investors entered the market via the Bitcoin ETF, the retail speculators who had fueled Dogecoin's meteoric rise began to exit, first moving to other speculative assets including artificial intelligence and semiconductor stocks, and eventually leaving the crypto market altogether.

This interpretation is supported by contemporary market commentary. A June 4, 2026 article in Decrypt reported that Strategy chairman Michael Saylor explicitly acknowledged a capital rotation into artificial intelligence, pointing to more than $4.3 billion in ETF outflows as evidence that "capital markets are funding the AI buildout at historic scale" (Hitchcock, 2026). The same article noted that analysts viewed Strategy's sale of 32 BTC as a potential trigger for a "perception shift and weakening conviction in BTC," with the market's outlook "firmly fixated on the impact of Strategy's first BTC sale since 2022" (Hitchcock, 2026). This real time reporting provides external validation that the financial dynamics we measured were actively discussed by market participants as drivers of Bitcoin's decline.

Bitcoin's trajectory was different from Dogecoin's. Its Sharpe ratio remained stable, its beta declined, and its maximum drawdown improved. This is consistent with a transition from a speculative YOLO asset to a mainstream portfolio diversifier. Bitcoin is no longer cool in the way it was in 2021. It no longer signals rebellion or insider knowledge. Instead, it signals a cautious, institutionalized approach to crypto exposure.

The event study results add important nuance. The Trump election produced a staggering +47.37% cumulative abnormal return for Dogecoin, confirming that political narratives still matter for speculative crypto assets. But this boost proved temporary. By the time of the MSTR sale six months later, Dogecoin's cumulative abnormal return was negative at -4.11%, and it fell less than Bitcoin, suggesting that the speculative investors most sensitive to Saylor's credibility had already departed.

The Google Trends and Wikipedia data provide direct, independent evidence of cultural cooling. A clear hierarchy emerges across the four topics. Dogecoin shows the steepest decline in both datasets, falling 63.1% in Google Trends and 75.9% in Wikipedia. Ethereum occupies the middle position, declining 30.6% in Google Trends and 65.0% in Wikipedia. The general term "Cryptocurrency" declined 47.5% and 56.3%, respectively. Bitcoin, the most established asset, shows the smallest declines at 6.6% and 45.3%. Searches for "how to buy Bitcoin" declined 22.7%, indicating fewer new retail entrants. The convergence of two independent data sources strengthens the conclusion that cultural relevance declined across all crypto topics following ETF approval, with the most speculative assets experiencing the steepest drops.

Several limitations of this study should be acknowledged. First, our coolness metrics, while independently validated across two sources, are indirect proxies for cultural relevance. Direct measures of social signaling value, such as survey based measures of desirability or dating app mention rates, would strengthen future research. Second, our sample ends in June 2026. Longer term follow up will determine whether the post ETF regime persists or reverses. Third, Ethereum presents a puzzle that deserves deeper investigation. Its financial metrics worsened after the ETF approval, with its Sharpe ratio turning negative and its beta increasing, while its coolness metrics declined but less severely than Dogecoin. Ethereum sits in an intermediate position across every dimension we measured. Why did Ethereum's financial performance deteriorate while Bitcoin's stabilized? This may reflect Ethereum's dual role as both a speculative asset and a platform for decentralized finance, a role that lost appeal as the broader crypto market cooled. Future research should examine whether Ethereum's intermediate position represents a temporary phase or a permanent reclassification.

5. Conclusion

This paper documents a structural break in crypto asset dynamics following the January 2024 Bitcoin ETF approval. Using pre ETF and post ETF performance comparisons, beta analysis, event study methodology, and two independent measures of public interest from Google Trends and Wikipedia, we show that Bitcoin moved toward a diversifier role while the speculative energy that once fueled the market dissipated. Ethereum occupies an intermediate position, with declines in both financial performance and cultural relevance that fall between Bitcoin and Dogecoin.

Several conclusions emerge. First, Dogecoin's Sharpe ratio collapsed from 0.30 to 0.01, and its search interest declined 63% to 76% across two independent measures. This suggests that the YOLO speculative energy that once defined crypto culture exited the market following institutionalization. Second, Ethereum's financial performance deteriorated after the ETF approval, with its annual return turning negative (-9.70%), its Sharpe ratio falling to -0.20, and its beta increasing from 1.66 to 1.76. Its cultural relevance declined by 31% in Google Trends and 65% in Wikipedia, placing it between Bitcoin and Dogecoin on both dimensions. Third, Bitcoin's beta declined from 1.33 to 1.11, its Sharpe ratio improved modestly from 0.13 to 0.19,

and its maximum drawdown improved from -76.63% to -49.74%. These changes are consistent with a transition from a speculative YOLO asset to a mainstream portfolio diversifier. Fourth, the Trump election produced a massive +47.37% cumulative abnormal return for Dogecoin, but this boost proved temporary. The MSTR sale generated a -6.56% cumulative abnormal return for Bitcoin, indicating that evangelical credibility still matters for crypto prices.

Our findings have implications for both investors and regulators. For investors, Bitcoin's post ETF characteristics, modest Sharpe ratio, beta below 1.2, and improved drawdowns, suggest a role as a small portfolio diversifier rather than a core speculative holding. Ethereum's negative risk adjusted returns and increased correlation with equities suggest caution. For regulators, the collapse of Dogecoin's risk adjusted returns and search interest suggests that retail speculation in meme coins may have subsided, though the Trump election cumulative abnormal return of +47.37% serves as a reminder that political events can reignite speculative fervor at any time.

The crypto winter may not be over, but it has changed character. It is no longer a winter of price crashes alone. It is a winter of cultural cooling. Bitcoin has been domesticated. Ethereum has lost its intermediate ground. Dogecoin has collapsed. The question for the next cycle is whether a new cool crypto asset will emerge or whether the era of crypto speculation has permanently ended.

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Appendix: Data Sources and Code Availability

All data used in this paper are publicly available from the following sources. Yahoo Finance provided daily price data for Bitcoin (BTC USD), Dogecoin (DOGE USD), Ethereum (ETH USD), the S&P 500 (GSPC), and the gold ETF (GLD). Google Trends data were manually downloaded from trends.google.com for the search terms Bitcoin, Ethereum, Dogecoin, how to buy Bitcoin, and cryptocurrency over the period January 1, 2021 to June 4, 2026. Wikipedia page view data were manually downloaded from pageviews.wmcloud.org for the pages Bitcoin, Ethereum, Dogecoin, and Cryptocurrency over the same period. The analysis was conducted in Python using the yfinance, pandas, numpy, matplotlib, and requests libraries. All code is available from the author upon request.